

A Star Fleet Battles™ Rule Proposal

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(G___.0) LOW-POWER TRACTOR BEAM

This rule describes an alternative operation mode of a ship's existing tractor beams.

After Y174, advances in Tractor Beam (G7.0) technology allowed options for less power to affect smaller objects at close range. This was not a new system, but instead mainly a refinement of the existing tractor beam emitter control software (along with operation protocols).

(G___.1) DEPLOYMENT

(G___.11) NO CAPABILITY REDUCTION: This is an additional mode of operation for a tractor beam. Except as explicitly stated in this rule, the additional mode does not reduce, change, or interfere with, the existing capabilities of tractor beams as described under (G7.0).

(G___.12) TRACTOR REQUIRED: A ship must already have at least one operational tractor beam.

(G___.13) AVAILABILITY: The control software changes were first developed in mid-Y175 by the Klingons, as a pre-cursor to the tractor-tether (G34.22); and, separately but simultaneously, by the Orions. The Federation Star Fleet's testing and certification processes resulted in deployment delays, and the new capability actually first appeared on ships of the Dragon Cartel before the Federation began rolling it out in late Y176. The Orions Pirates and Klingons both started deployment by late Y175; the Lyrans, having received the necessary information from the Klingons, started in early Y176; the Kzinti quickly copied it and began their rollout in mid-Y176. By early Y177, practically every Alpha Octant empire (and Cartel) that wanted to could deploy the change; an exception was the Andromedans, who were not known to use this mode until Y180 (it was suggested, but never proven, that one of the Cartels sold the key details to the Andromedans in exchange for being left alone).

(G___.14) REFIT: While technically a refit, the deployment of this capability does not involve physical modifications to a ship. There is no BPV change when a ship gains this system.

(G___.2) POWER

(G___.21) POWER REQUIRED: When operated in low-power mode, a tractor beam only requires one-half a point of power. This creates a technical exception to (G7.15). The power may come from any source.

(G___.22) EFFECTIVE TRACTOR LIMITED: The beam created has one point of effective tractor (G7.6). This cannot be increased in low-power mode.

(G___.23) MODE EXITED: An existing low-power tractor beam may be switched to a "normal" tractor beam by application of at least one-half a point of power from any source. This may take place during Energy Allocation or at any other point in an impulse where power may be added to a tractor beam. It is not necessary for the generating ship to "drop" the "low-power" beam in order for it to attach a "normal" beam.

(G___.231) Once additional power is applied, an existing beam may not return to operation as a "low-power" tractor beam.

(G___.232) Engaging in a tractor auction (G7.42) automatically exits low-power mode for a low-power beam participating in the auction.

(G___.233) Once an existing tractor beam has exited low-power mode, its operation is thereafter entirely governed by (G7.0); that is, the fact that it was once operated in low-power mode has no further effect. In particular, this means the exception to (G7.15) is nullified at the time the beam exits low-power mode.

(G___.3) OPERATION

(G___.31) ALL TRACTORS ENABLED: Any ship-mounted tractor beam, including Andromedan Tractor-Repulsor Beams operated as tractors (E9.4), may be operated in low-power mode.

(G___.32) REQUIREMENTS: When operated in low-power mode, all other functional requirements are the same as normal operation; for example, lock-on is required, terrain may prevent operation, *etc.*

(G___.33) LIMITED RANGE: A tractor beam operated in low-power mode has a maximum range of one hex.

(G___.34) TARGET SIZE LIMITED: Only objects that are Size Class 6, or smaller, may be tractoried by a beam operated in low-power mode. However, drogues (G34.0) may not be deployed, towed or retrieved using this mode (an inert drogue not deployed for combat could be moved using a low-power tractor to, for example, transfer it between friendly ships).

(G___.35) ROTATION LIMITED: An object held in a low-power beam may be rotated under (G7.7), except that the object cannot be rotated away from the ship generating the tractor beam (even if being moved from range 0 to range 1).

(G___.36) RECOVERY ENABLED: A friendly shuttle (or other small object otherwise recoverable *via* tractor beam) may be recovered (J1.62) by a ship using a low-power tractor beam.

(G___.37) DEATH DRAGGING PROHIBITED: Attempting to death-drag a shuttle under (G7.54) when holding it in a low-power tractor beam breaks the beam before harming or moving the shuttle, even if the shuttle is crippled.

(G___.38) SEEKING WEAPONS HELD: A drone, or a suicide shuttle, may be held at range 1 by a low-power tractor beam. This rule is subordinate to (G___.37).

(G___.39) MINESWEEPING ENABLED: A low-power tractor beam is able to satisfy the minesweeping tractor-beam requirement of (M8.11).

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